

devouring and status-seeking Organization Man and their nervously shrill-voiced, apprehensive wives will hardly be surprised by this revelation.

I am unable to see that the achievement of any degree of social status is worth the price of a man's life or the destruction of his or his family's health. Assuredly, there is

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something very wrong basically when human beings are willing to sell their lives and their health so cheaply. Nor am I able to see that money or the dubious benefits conferred by the attainment of what passes for status are worth the price of one's individuality and personal integrity. I am apparently in the minority. It is becoming increasingly apparent that it's no longer fashionable to pay much heed to these considerations. Their value has been swept aside in the pell-mell rush to conform to what is regarded as the majority view—which regards the accumulation of money and material things and the gaining of status as the approved goals and places no ceiling on the price which can be paid for achieving them.

I consider it one of the major tragedies of our civilization that people have come to regard it virtually mandatory to imitate in order to win the social acceptance of their fellows. The end result of this can only be to reduce even the most brilliant individuals to a sterile cipher.

Toady and lickspittle are nasty words. The average man would probably be inclined to use his fists on anyone who called him either. Yet, countless men will lower themselves to such absurd devices as wearing bow ties because their employers wear them, cutting their hair the way their superiors do, or buying their homes where the other executives buy theirs. They ape and echo the ideas, views and actions of those they seek to impress, proving nothing but that they are servile toadies. Imitation may be the most sincere form of flattery—but it *is* imitation, and flattery is nothing more than a pat on the head from someone who knows he deserves a kick in the behind.

I once obtained control of a company and was immediately —and far from favorably—impressed by the fawning attitude of the majority of the firm's executives.